Week 17: New Testament Letters (Historical Context)

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

New Testament letters were written to real people in real situations — tonight we'll start looking at the history behind them.

1. Have you ever read a text, email, or letter that wasn't written to you — or one where you didn't know the full backstory — and completely misread what was going on? What changed once you learned the context?

2. **Read Philippians 1:1-11.** What does Paul say he does every time he remembers the Philippians, and what specifically does he thank God for (vv. 3-5)? What does it tell you that Paul begins his letters with real, specific gratitude for actual people, rather than a general theological statement?

3. **Read Philippians 1:12-26.** What does Paul say has happened as a result of his imprisonment, and how has it affected the people around him (vv. 12-14)? Knowing he's writing these words as a literal prisoner of Rome, how does that change the weight of what he says here about joy and purpose?

4. **Read Philippians 2:1-11.** What does this passage say Jesus had, and what did he do with it instead of holding onto it (vv. 6-8)? In a culture obsessed with honor, status, and climbing the social ladder, how radical would Jesus "emptying himself" and taking on the nature of a servant have sounded to people used to gods and emperors flaunting their power rather than giving it up?

5. **Read Philippians 3:1-11.** What credentials does Paul list for himself, and what word does he use for them by comparison to knowing Christ (vv. 4-8)? Given that other churches (like Galatia) were being pressured by traveling teachers to adopt circumcision, what situation do you think Paul is responding to here?

6. **Read Philippians 4:2-3.** Who does Paul name in this passage, and what does he specifically ask them to do? What does it tell you that Paul is willing to name an actual, specific conflict in the letter rather than speaking only in the abstract?

7. **Read Philippians 4:10-19.** What does Paul say the Philippians did for him, and what does he say no other church had done (v. 15)? How does learning that part of the occasion for this letter was a thank-you for their financial support change the way you read everything that came before it?

8. A line like "I can do all this through him who gives me strength" (Philippians 4:13) gets lifted out and printed on coffee mugs as a promise of personal achievement — but in context, Paul is talking specifically about being content whether he has plenty or nothing. What's a "sound-byte" Bible verse you've heard used out of context? Does knowing the real situation behind it change how you hear it?

9. Roman society ran on a strict hierarchy — wealth, family name, and status determined your worth, and everyone below the top was expected to know their place. Where do you see the gospel Paul describes in Philippians pushing back against that hierarchy?

10. Paul wrote this letter to friends he deeply loved, in the middle of his own hardship, to encourage them in theirs. Is there someone in your life right now who could use that kind of letter from you — grounded in your shared history and their specific situation? What would you want to say?